

Guru Nanak



Gurudwara Granth Sahib, Kartarpur

Guru Nanak's Teachings: Guru Nanak preached that God is without form and wanted his followers to practice meditation upon the name of God for peace and ultimate salvation. He is considered the first guru by the Sikhs. Guru Nanak had great contempt for Vedic rituals and caste discriminations. The teachings of Guru Nanak formed the basis of Sikhism, a new religious order, founded in the late 15th century. His and his successors' teachings are collected in the *Guru Granth Sahib,* which is the holy book of the Sikhs. Guru Nanak's teachings were spread through the group singing of hymns, called *kirtan*. The devotees gathered in *dharmashalas* (rest houses), which became *gurudwaras* in course of time.

Guru Nanak nominated his disciple Lehna to succeed him as the guru. Following this precedent, the successors are named by the incumbent Sikh Guru. At the time of



Five distinctive things of the *Khalsa* members

Guru Gobind Singh, the custom of *pahul* (baptism by sweetened water stirred with a dagger) was introduced. Those who got baptised became members of a disciplined brotherhood known as the *Khalsa* (meaning the pure). The men were given the title Singh (lion). Every member of the *Khalsa* had to have five distinctive things on his person. These were *kesh* (uncut hair), *kangha* (comb), *kirpan* (dagger), *kada* (steel bangle) and *kachera* (underpants). After Guru Gobind Singh, the holy book *Guru Granth Sahib* is considered the guru and its message is spread by the *Khalsa*.